

Modifiers

Modifiers are words, phrases, and clauses that affect and often enhance the meaning of a sentence. Modifiers offer detail that can make a sentence more engaging, clearer, or specific. The simplest form of a modifier would be an adjective or adverb.

Misplaced vs dangling modifiers

A misplaced modifier is too far away from the thing it's supposed to modify, while a dangling modifier's intended subject is missing from the sentence altogether. It is a phrase or clause that is not clearly and logically related to the word or words it modifies.

Misplaced Modifiers

A misplaced modifier is a word, phrase, or clause that is improperly separated from the word it modifies / describes. Because of the separation, sentences with this error often sound awkward or confusing.

There are several kinds of misplaced modifiers:

1. Misplaced adjectives are incorrectly separated from the nouns they modify and almost always distort the intended meaning.

Example 1:

The child ate a **cold dish** of cereal for breakfast this morning.
↑
misplaced adjective (modifies *dish*)

Correct the error by placing the adjective *next to the noun it modifies*.

Corrected

The child ate a dish of **cold cereal** for breakfast this morning.
↑
correctly placed adjective (modifies *cereal*)

Example 2:

The **torn student's** book lay on the desk.

↑
misplaced adjective (modifies *student*)

Corrected

The student's **torn book** lay on the desk

↑
correctly placed adjective (modifies *book*)

2. Misplaced adverbs can also change meaning in sentences.

We ate the lunch that we had brought **slowly**.

To repair the meaning, move the adverb slowly so that it is near *ate*.

We **slowly** ate the lunch that we had brought.

3. Misplaced phrases may cause a sentence to sound awkward and may create a meaning that does not make sense.

Example 1 (a buyer with leather seats?)

The dealer sold the Cadillac to the  **buyer with leather seats**.

Corrected

The dealer sold the  **Cadillac with leather seats** to the buyer.

Example 2 (a corner smoking pipes?)

The three bankers talked quietly in the  **corner smoking pipes**.

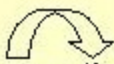
Corrected

The three  **bankers smoking pipes** talked quietly in the corner.

4. Misplaced clauses may cause a sentence to sound awkward and may create a meaning that does not make sense.

Example (a hamper that Ralph wore?)

Ralph piled all of his clothes in the **hamper that he had worn**.



Corrected

Ralph piled all of his **clothes that he had worn** in the hamper.



Dangling modifier

A dangling modifier's intended subject is missing from the sentence altogether. It is a phrase or clause that is not clearly and logically related to the word or words it modifies.

Example 1

Looking toward the west, a funnel shaped cloud stirred up dust.

↑
dangling modifier

This sentence does not specify who is looking toward the west. In fact, there is nothing at all in the sentence to which the modifying phrase looking toward the west can logically refer. Since the modifier, looking toward the west, is sitting next to the funnel shaped cloud, the sentence suggests that the cloud is doing the looking.

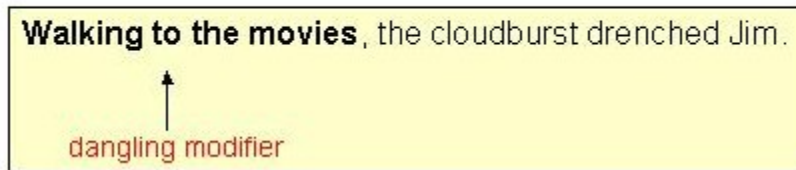
Example 2

When nine years old, my mother enrolled in medical school.

↑
dangling modifier

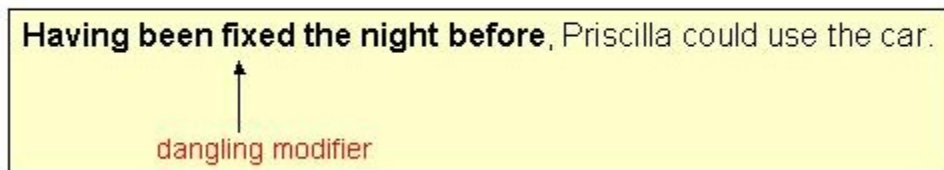
At other times the dangling modifier is placed next to the wrong noun.

Example 1



Because of the placement of walking to the movies, this sentence suggests that the cloudburst is walking to the movies even though a possible walker - Jim - is mentioned later.

Example 2



Since having been fixed the night before is placed next to Priscilla, the sentence means that Priscilla was fixed the night before.

The above examples show, dangling modifiers result in inaccurate and sometimes ludicrous statements.

How to correct dangling modifiers

Dangling modifiers may be corrected in two general ways:

Correction Method #1

1. Leave the modifier as it is.
2. Change the main part of the sentence so that it begins with the term actually modified.
3. This change will put the modifier next to the term it modifies.

Thus, this dangling modifier

Looking toward the west, a funnel shaped cloud stirred up dust.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to


Looking toward the west, **I** saw a funnel shaped cloud stir up dust.

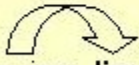
Now the sentence means that **I was looking toward the west**.

Using the same method, this dangling modifier

Walking to the movies, the cloudburst drenched Jim.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to


Walking to the movies, **Jim** was drenched by the cloudburst.

Now the sentence means that **Jim was drenched by the cloudburst**.

Correction Method #2

1. Change the dangling modifier phrase to a subordinate clause, creating a subject and verb.
2. Leave the rest of the sentence as it is.

Thus, the dangling modifier

When nine years old, my mother enrolled in medical school.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to

When I was nine years old, my mother enrolled in medical school.

↑ ↑
subject verb

Using the same method, the dangling modifier

Having been fixed the night before, Priscilla could use the car.

↑
dangling modifier

may be corrected to

Since the car had been fixed the night before, Priscilla could use it.

↑ ↑
subject verb